

I was told that AI only contributes as much energy usage as other things such as video games or social media. Does anyone have any proof?

Posted by u/rainwingss_ • 0 points • 50 comments

I'm asking because this could change my view on AI entirely. I would like to know if AI power usage or data centres contribute an equal amount of harm as other socially accepted Internet or digital items.

Comments

u/RedQueenNatalie • 1 points • 2025-10-24 17:23 UTC

Of all things ai being in data centers is not the worst. They are run that way because it is the most efficient possible way to do it due to consolidated cooling systems and other support hardware. You can run LLM and image generation on home computers and check for yourself how much power it uses , on a per user basis it simply isn't that much. The trouble right now is hyper-over investment in a technology based on pure speculation.

u/ReasonableCat1980 • 1 points • 2025-10-23 15:35 UTC

This is true with the exception of making video

u/the_tallest_fish • 1 points • 2025-10-23 04:26 UTC

In [this report](<https://www.technologyreview.com/2025/05/20/1116327/ai-energy-usage-climate-footprint-big-tech/>), which belongs to the series of MIT reports that first raised energy concerns of AI usage, suggest that generating a very high quality image would take 4,402 joules.

> That's equivalent to about 250 feet on an e-bike, or around five and a half seconds running a microwave.

The concerns raised by these reports were never about how energy consumption of AI per user, it's regarding the fact that a few data centers in the US are supplying for most of the global AI demand, which takes up 4.4% of total energy consumption by the US.

u/Historical_Sand7487 • 1 points • 2025-10-23 00:20 UTC

McDonald's burgers use a lot of water is always my comeback. But ut doesn't really work, just kinda hard ends the conversation with awkward silence

u/No-Whole3083 • 1 points • 2025-10-22 10:05 UTC

If you are worried about consumption and how it factor into your opinion I'd say to you, life is consumption. You are never going to cut out any of the meaningful forms of consumption. If you ate a hamburger you used 20X more water than a full day of prompting. If you drove a car you already took out some damage to the enviornment. Typing this post you already burned a tree or some kind of fossil fuel so to what end are you willing to accept doing things has a cost?

To answer your question, for the benefit compute gives us, the commodity cost is a drop in the bucket next to traditional industry.

u/Fit-Elk1425 • 1 points • 2025-10-22 03:21 UTC

If you want a good summary of everything to do with energy andy masley substack does a decent job <https://andymasley.substack.com/p/ai-and-the-environment>

u/MaiMaiKaye • 1 points • 2025-10-22 03:17 UTC

People will sit on their lazy asses streaming themselves playing video games for hours on end while screaming at their chat that if they don't make the donation goal, they will cut the stream early. But that isn't wasteful?

u/Asleep_Stage_451 • 2 points • 2025-10-22 03:01 UTC

For perspective, your post here contributed to more electricity usage than my ChatGPT usage for a month.

Here is another example for you using water as the measure.

<https://preview.redd.it/cj4433imwkwf1.png?width=1085&format=png&auto=webp&s=49379bb63596aa167a8271cac04d20234c72a02f>

u/rtrs_bastiat • 1 points • 2025-10-22 01:57 UTC

Depends what you're doing I guess. Images can be generated locally in a matter of seconds so they're going to be fairly low energy. I struggled with generating text locally but that's down to the vram of my gpu rather than the power I can provide it, but that bottleneck would cause some multiplier to power consumption if we couldn't make use of data centres to get the work done for us. A simple request uses about 0.3Wh of energy, pretty similar to any other web request searching a large dataset (Google search, Amazon search, etc.). I mostly use text generation for agentic coding, which will have a much larger context so a larger footprint. If I had to guess I'm intensive cases like that the energy consumption would be somewhere between streaming Netflix and playing a game that will test your GPU quite frequently. Honestly, if you're worried about the environmental impact of a typical person's AI consumption then the way to make it green would be for that one person to cut out one snack a week.

u/xweert123 • 3 points • 2025-10-21 22:28 UTC

The reality is more nuanced than either side makes it out to be. Some quick facts are:

1. *****Using***** AI Generation Models from a Datacenter or Locally after they have already been built/trained uses about the same amount of energy as many other things people do every day. Specifically, this accounts for your impact as an individual. Actually using an AI Model has very negligible power demands
2. Datacenters themselves, however, have accounted for tons of power consumption, with their power consumption usage skyrocketing due to AI, and their demand has skyrocketed since the rapid development of AI. AI is directly responsible for Google and Microsoft failing to reach their emission

goals miserably, and are scrambling to find solutions to fix this. Google in particular, despite working hard to reduce their emissions, have actually begun producing MORE emissions since their latest report, directly due to AI usage. Microsoft has also raised their Emissions by 7% due to AI, although they haven't considered themselves as failing to reach their goals, yet. Emissions are the way that they are for these companies because of the energy demands of running these models in a data center. In layman's terms, the consumption required to train and maintain these models is increasing faster than the emission countermeasures we fund and develop to counteract the increase in power consumption, at the moment. It's a pretty major bottleneck.

With that being said, Google and Microsoft are also some of the companies that spend the most amount of money into developing zero emission solutions for their AI models, but the fear is that the technology's rapid evolution requires so much energy that they won't be able to both upgrade and evolve the models *and* keep emissions low. Which, so far, has been proven correct.

Ultimately, the reality of the situation is, we as individuals using AI aren't consuming much energy at all, but AI Datacenters use a TON of electricity, oftentimes as much as the other pieces of technology we use that is infamous for how demanding it is. We just have to hope these mega corporations do a good job and find a way to solve these issues, as they've blown well past their emission goals due to AI. But actual AI users themselves aren't really the problem, especially when it comes to Local AI models, since using a Local AI model uses about as much energy as playing an intensive game on your PC.

u/Mataric • 2 points • 2025-10-21 21:44 UTC

A lot of us run this stuff on our home PC and we pay the power bills (not to mention have a limit on the amount of power our PC can use in the 2 to 5 seconds it takes to create an image etc).

Atop that, yes - there's a lot of data out there. Your reddit post here would have used a TON more power overall than pretty much any kind of publicly available AI generation/LLM.

AI is just math. Computers are good at math. When AI is run off a server, they're also a little bit of networking - (A send, some processing, a receive then the opposite on the return journey).

Your reddit post takes less math, but a ton more networking. It's pushed into their database, then that database entry is fed to hundreds (if not thousands) of people. Every comment someone makes, it gets sent to reddit, then sent to you, then sent to everyone else who views the thread. Every time someone upvotes or downvotes a comment on the thread, it's all sent back to the servers and stored in the database.

Reddit is actually one of the worst social media platforms from an energy cost angle. If you're concerned about the power usage of AI, start with social media. If you compare the overall energy costs of both (and I definitely appreciate AI is growing fast and will increase), right now AI would be completely ignored as a rounding error if you combined AI with social media. It is exponentially worse.